

MASTER MANIPULATOR
Sanjay Rai 'Sherpuria' speaking at the National Dairy Mela in Karnal, Apr. 11

CRIME

FOOLING THE POWERFUL

duped of sums as paltry as Rs 2,500 to Rs 5,000 for illusory government jobs. Not to mention senior bureaucrats, who often approached him with requests to "put in a good word" with the high-ups for favourable transfers and postings.

If Sherpuria's long list of cons is dramatic—including for the fact that he, too, committed those by faking access to the PMO—so is the story of his rise from waiting tables at a restaurant to launching a string of companies in Ahmedabad to then hobnobbing with Delhi's power elite and getting feted as a "social entrepreneur". Indeed, the script, pieced together from the FIR lodged by the Uttar Pradesh Police and sources in its special task force (STF), seems readymade for Bollywood.

The initial details are a bit sketchy. Born in Assam, where his father was reportedly running an army canteen, Sherpuria moved to Gujarat in 1999. Starting as a waiter, he "fell in love" with the restaurant owner's daughter, and soon married into the wealthy and "well-connected" family. That, according to sources, is how he came in contact with Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders and other politicians in Gujarat even as he scaled up on the business front, taking over some of his wife's firms and getting into petrochemicals, energy and food processing (his firms have a combined liability to the tune of Rs 350 crore, says a source in the STF).

Faking access to the PMO, Sherpuria duped industrialists, babus and even jobless youths, pocketing crores

It was after the 2014 Lok Sabha election that Sherpuria decided to shift base to Delhi and UP. This is where the story gets really intriguing. Apparently using his father's old contacts in the army, he managed to rent a part of an upscale property on Lodhi Road in Delhi and started to claim that he resided in a "bungalow behind Race Course" to show his proximity to the PMO—7, Race Course Road (renamed Lok Kalyan Marg in 2016) being the official residence of the PM. He even hired a PR firm to make fan pages on social media platforms showing him in pictures with the likes of RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, PM Modi, Union ministers Giriraj Singh, Dharmendra Pradhan and Sarbananda Sonowal, to name a few. He also started moving around with private security in tow to show off his "VVIP status".

But how did Sherpuria manage to get his pictures clicked with India's power elite? "He often sponsored events of media houses," says the STF source, "who would then call some MP or minister as chief guest, giving him an opportunity to share the stage with them." Sherpuria also authored a few books, which he managed to get released by eminent personalities, the pictures making their way to his fan pages.

According to sources, he used to hold 'pujas' at his Lodhi Road residence and invite politicians and bureaucrats. He would "trap" the government officials by sending them lavish presents. During meetings, he would drop prominent names, thus flaunting his fake PMO connection. Whenever a bureaucrat searched for information about him online, they would come across his pictures alongside the top ministers and leaders, enough to convince them about his claims. Donating money for